



SOCIAL CONSTRUCTION OF REALITY

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The term **Social Construction Of Reality** refers to the theory that the way we present ourselves to other people is shaped partly by our interactions with others, as well as by our life experiences. How we were raised and what we were raised to believe affect how we present ourselves, how

- Our reality is also a complicated negotiation. What is real depends on what is socially acceptable. Most social interactions involve some acceptance of what's going on. While we participate in the construction of reality, it's not

Example: A wealthy individual, whose basic survival needs are met many times over, buys his pets gourmet, organic food that costs more per week than the weekly earnings of a minimum-wage worker. He is proud that he is able to take such good care of his animals and insists that it's the right thing to do if one really loves one's pets. After all, his vet was the one who recommended that he buy that brand. A minimum-wage worker who loads that food into the rich person's

- How we define everyday situations depends on our respective backgrounds and experiences. The wealthy individual has learned through interactions with others that spending money on one's pets is a worthy expense. His reality is one of pride. The minimum-wage worker has learned through interactions with others spending

Social Construction of Reality according to Peter Berger and Thomas Luckman

- Theory that assumes that understanding, significance and meaning are created not within the individual, but in coordination with other human beings.
 - Human beings rationalize their experiences by creating a model of the social world and how it works.
 - Language is the essential system to help us establish that reality.
- What we believe is real is shaped by our social interactions and our life experiences with other people.

Social Construction of Reality

According to **Berger and Luckman**, society is constructed through three stages:

- **Externalization**- we create cultural products (values, beliefs, material products) through social interaction. These products become external to those who have produced them.
- **Objectification**- is when products created in the first stage appear to take on a reality of their own, becoming independent of those who created them.
- **Internalization**- we learn the supposedly "objective facts" about the cultural products that have been created. This occurs primarily through socialization, the process of social interaction in which one learns the ways of society.

Social Construction of Situations

- **Thomas Theorem (W. I. Thomas)**

- “If a person perceives a situation as real, it is real in its consequences”
- Our behavior depends on our subjective interpretation of reality.

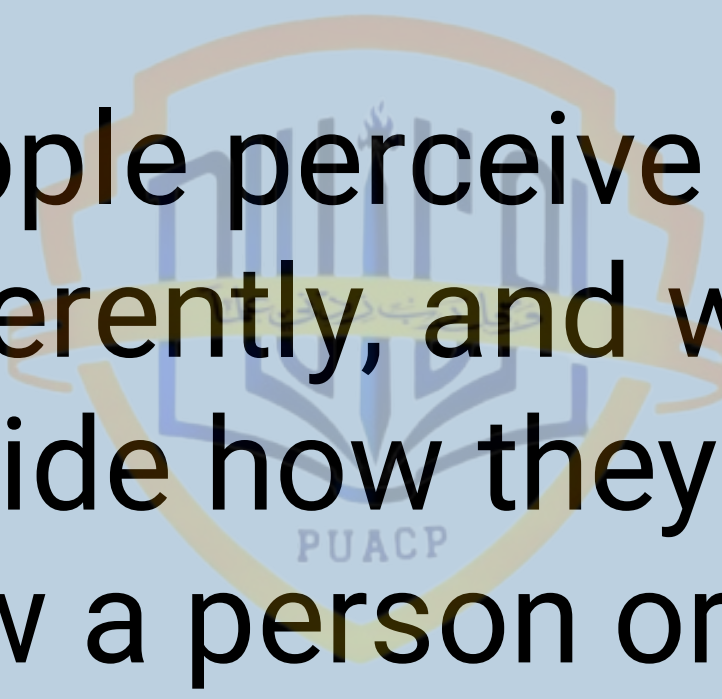
- **Definition of a Situation**

- The idea that people create of what is expected of them and others in a given

The Thomas Theorem

- What is the “real” reality? Is buying a pet expensive food the right thing to do or a waste of money? According to sociologist W. I. Thomas, “if a person perceives a situation as real, it is real in its consequences.” This statement

- In other words, our behavior depends not on the objective reality of a situation but on our subjective interpretation of reality. The consequences and results of behavior make it real. For example, a teenager who is defined as deviant might begin to act deviant. He makes his label real.

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- People perceive reality differently, and when they decide how they are going to view a person or a situation, they act accordingly. Since we all perceive reality differently, our reactions differ. Our definition of a situation as good or bad to